

Emergence of Bangladesh
North South University
Dhaka, Bangladesh
SaMS, HIS 103

Bengali Hindu Renaissance

- **Bengal Renaissance** refers largely to the **social, cultural, psychological, and intellectual changes** in Bengal during the nineteenth century, as a result of contact between **certain sympathetic British officials** and missionaries on the one hand, and the Hindu intelligentsia on the other.
- The setting for the Bengal Renaissance was the colonial metropolis of Calcutta.

- There were **four aspects** of the **Renaissance movement**, which the Bangali intelligentsia developed systematically throughout the nineteenth century.
- **First**, there was the modernization of the Bengali language and the simultaneous birth of a new Bangali literature.
- **Secondly**, there was the **rediscovery** of, and identification with an Indian classical era hailed as a **golden age** which placed **South Asian civilisation** on a par with the grandeur of **Greece and Rome**.
- **Thirdly**, there was the Sreerampore missionary interpretation of the Protestant Reformation, which Indians applied creatively to their own historic situation.
- **And finally**, there was the **secular view of universal progress** on which India's hope lay not in resurrecting the past but in projecting the **golden age into the future**.

- When the **College of Fort William** hired the Baptist missionary, **WILLIAM CAREY** in 1801, as head of the Bengali Department every available kind of financial, technological, and human resource was put at his disposal.

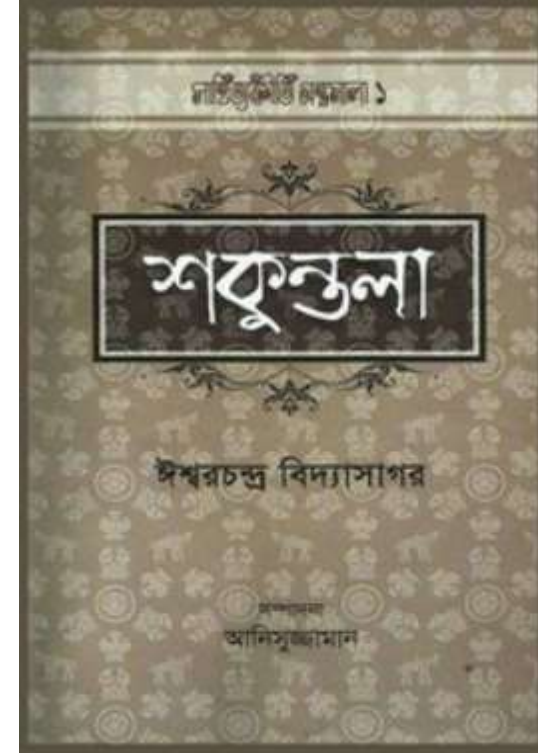
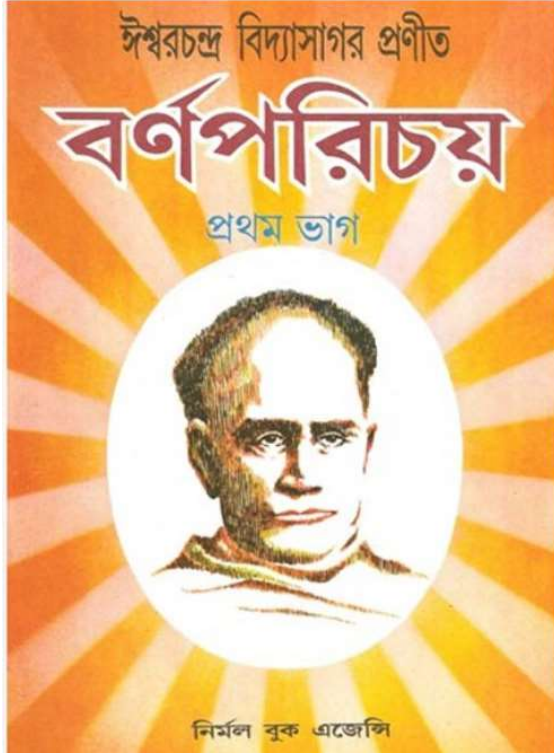


Ishwar Chandra
Vidyasagar



- **Vidyasagar, Ishwar Chandra (1820-1891)** Sanskrit scholar, writer, educationist, humanist pundit, social reformer and philanthropist, was born on 26 September 1820 in a poor BRAHMAN family in a village in Medinipur. His father Thakur Das Bandhyay was a clerk at a shop in Kolkata
- Vidyasagar did not write in one single style; for example, the style he followed in his textbooks was, of course, different from the one he used in his literary works.
- Passing of the Hindu Widow's Remarriage Act

- The Hindu Widow's Re-marriage Act, 1856 (For details, see the link: <http://bdlaws.minlaw.gov.bd/act-9.html>)
- Marriage of Hindu widows legalized



বর্ণপরিচয়

দ্বিতীয় ভাগ

সংযুক্ত বর্ণ

ঈশ্বরচন্দ্র বিদ্যাসাগর প্রণীত



য-ফলা



গা
ম
ল
অ
র
ণ্য



ক য কা চ য চ্য ট য ট্য ত য ত

ক য কা	ঐক্য, বাক্য, মাণিক্য
খ য খ্য	মুখ্য, খ্যাতি, অখ্যাতি, উপাখ্যান
গ য গ্য	ভাগ্য, যোগ্য, আরোগ্য
চ য চ্য	বাচ্য, বিবেচ্য, চ্যুত, পদচ্যুত
জ য জ্য	রাজ্য, ভোজ্য, জ্যোতিষ
ট য ট্য	নাট্য, কাপট্য, নৈকট্য
ঠ য ঠ্য	লাঠা, পাঠা, শাঠা
ড য ড্য	জাড়্য, তাড়্যমান
ঢ য ঢ্য	আঢ্য, ধনাঢ্য
ণ য ণ্য	পুণ্য, অরণ্য, লাবণ্য
ত য ত্য	নিত্য, সত্য, ত্যাগ, মৃত্যু
থ য থ্য	তথ্য, পথ্য, মিথ্যা
দ য দ্য	অদ্য, বাদ্য, বিদ্যা, বিদ্যৎ
ধ য ধ্য	বাস্য, ধ্যান, অসাধ্য

প্রথম পাঠ

- ১। কখনও কাহাকে কুবাক্য কহিও না। কুবাক্য কহা বড় দোষ। যে কুবাক্য কহে, কেহ তাহাকে দেখিতে পারে না।
- ২। বাল্যকালে মন দিয়া লেখাপড়া শিখিবে। লেখাপড়া শিখিলে, সকলে তোমায় ভালবাসিবে। যে লেখাপড়ায় আলস্য করে, কেহ তাহাকে ভালবাসে না। তুমি কখনও লেখাপড়ায় আলস্য করিও না।
- ৩। সদা সত্য কথা কহিবে। যে সত্য কথা কয়, সকলে তাহাকে ভালবাসে। যে মিথ্যা কথা কয়, কেহ তাহাকে ভালবাসে না; সকলেই তাহাকে ঘৃণা করে। তুমি কখনও মিথ্যা কথা কহিও না।
- ৪। নিত্য যাহা পড়িবে, নিত্য তাহা অভ্যাস করিবে। কল্য অভ্যাস করিব বলিয়া রাখিয়া দিবে না। যাহা রাখিয়া দিবে, আর তাহা অভ্যাস করিতে পারিবে না।

৩। সদা সত্য কথা কহিবে। যে সত্য কথা কয়, সকলে তাহাকে ভালবাসে। যে মিথ্যা কথা কয়, কেহ তাহাকে ভালবাসে না; সকলেই তাহাকে ঘৃণা করে। তুমি কখনও মিথ্যা কথা কহিও না।

৪। নিত্য যাহা পড়িবে, নিত্য তাহা অভ্যাস করিবে। কল্য অভ্যাস করিব বলিয়া রাখিয়া দিবে না। যাহা রাখিয়া দিবে, আর তাহা অভ্যাস করিতে পারিবে না।

৫। কদাচ পিতামাতার অবাধ্য হইও না। তাঁহারা যখন যাহা বলিবেন, তাহা করিবে। কদাচ তাহার অমুখা করিও না। পিতামাতার কথা না শুনিলে, তাঁহারা তোমায় ভালবাসিবেন না।

৬। অবোধ বালকেরা সারাদিন খেলিয়া বেড়ায়, লেখাপড়ায় মন দেয় না। এজন্য তাহারা চিরকাল দুঃখ পায়। যাহারা মন দিয়া লেখাপড়া শিখে, তাহারা চিরকাল সুখে থাকে।

ঈশ্বরচন্দ্র বিদ্যাসাগর

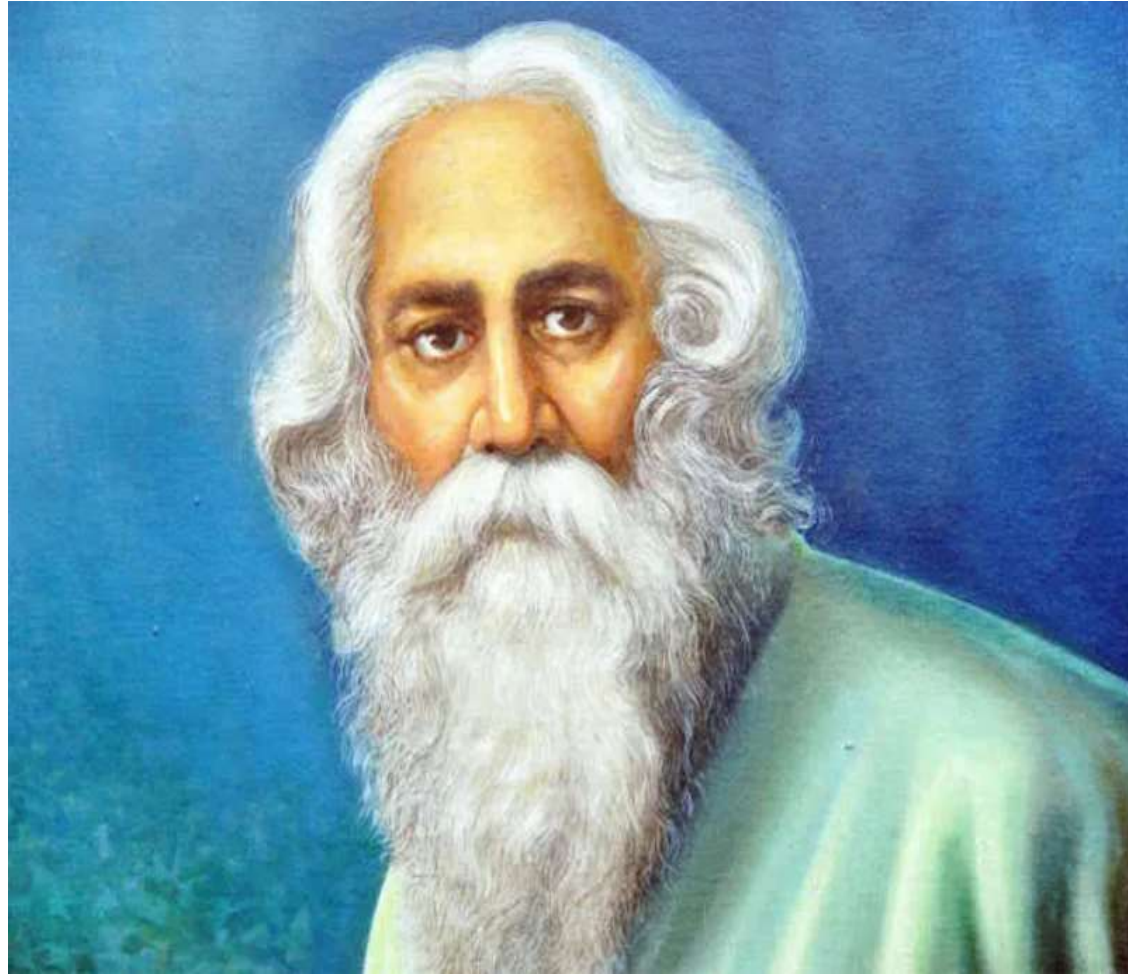
- Ishwar Chandra Vidyasagar will be more remembered as one of the greatest intellectuals and activists of the 19-century and the 'Father of modern Bengali prose.'

- If Rammohun Roy played the role of the first humanist pundit in Bengal by translating, reinterpreting and publishing old shastras, and thus started the process of the Bengal Renaissance, Vidyasagar was the second. Whereas the former did it mainly for his campaign against [SATI](#), the latter did it for the remarriage of child widows, stopping polygamy, introducing female education and for improving the condition of the down-trodden in society, particularly women.

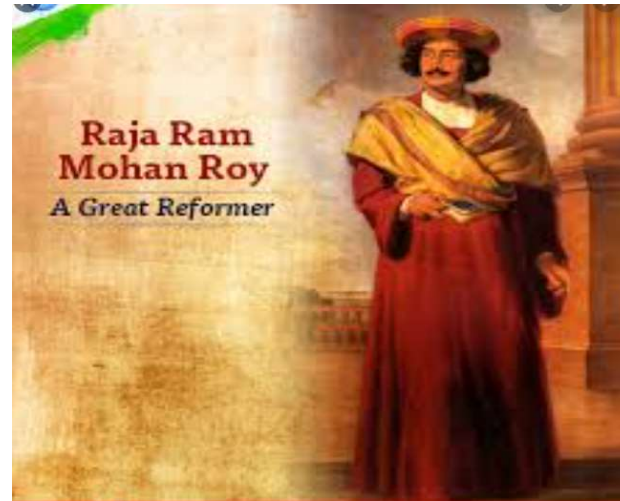
- Writers such as MICHAEL MADHUSUDAN DUTT (1824-73) and RABINDRANATH TAGORE (1861-1941) wrote beautifully in English but that they also chose to express their literary genius creatively in Bangali certainly helped shape the **renaissance of that literature**. Dutt's *Meghnadhbadh Kabya* and Tagore's GEETANJALI for examples, were renaissance **masterpieces** in the manner that tradition was modernized. It is of no small importance that Tagore was awarded the **Nobel Prize for Literature in 1913**, one year after he published an English translation of *Geetanjali* (Song Offerings).



Poet Michael Madhusudan Dutta has written the book Meghnad Badh Kavya.



- If the Bengal Renaissance produced one outstanding progenitor who imbibed the Orientalist contribution as effectively as he did linguistic and literary modernization and the effective defense of Hindu theism against the double-edged challenge of Christianity and secularism, it would be RAMMOHUN ROY



- **Roy, Raja Rammohun** (1772/74-1833) the great reformer, was born in a **conservative Brahmin family** in the village Radhanagar, West Bengal. He received the traditional education that was common in 18th century India. During his boyhood and early youth he had acquired **remarkable proficiency** in several oriental languages such as **Sanskrit, Arabic, Persian, besides Hindi and his mother tongue Bangla**.
- He became well versed in Hindu religious scriptures and through his **close contact with Muslim scholars** and officials of the revenue and judicial departments of the EAST INDIA COMPANY's government gained considerable knowledge of **Islamic theology and jurisprudence**. It may be noted that **until 1837** the East India Company's Government as the language of **official** business in revenue and judicial transactions retained Persian. After Rammohun settled in Calcutta and published his translation of the ***Vedanta*** in **1815**.

- **Raja Ram Mohan Roy** was the founder of the **Brahma Samaj**, which played a **major role** in reforming and modernising the Indian society. In August 1828 Rammohun founded the '**BRAHMA SABHA**' or Society of God, which in fact emerged as a new sect of Hinduism. He **inaugurated the great age of Hindu reform**. The public opinion, which he was able to arouse against the **evil practice of SATEE**, (the custom of **burning of widows upon the funeral pyres of their deceased husbands**) influenced the government to **abolish it in 1829** through a special legislation. He denounced the **Hindu caste system**.

- **গৌড়ীয় ব্যাকরণ** বাঙালি রচিত প্রথম বাংলা **ব্যাকরণ**। রচয়িতা রাজা **রামমোহন রায়**, প্রকাশিত ১৮৩৩ খ্রিস্টাব্দে





- **Raja Ram Mohan Roy** also contributed much to the **growth of national consciousness** in the subcontinent. In his political views he was greatly influenced by the philosophy of **Jeremy Bentham**. Principle of “utilitarianism”: Welfare of the people –**Greatest happiness of the greatest number of the people.**
- **Rammohun and other Bengali leaders who followed him were loyal supporters of the British raj.** They believed that in course of time the **political privileges** that the British people at home were enjoying would be extended to the people of the British territories overseas.

- In 1830 Rammohun Roy left for England to represent to the British king and parliament the grievances of the titular **Mughal Emperor Akbar II (1806-1837)**, who had invested him with the title of 'Raja'. In England he was **widely acclaimed** by leaders of British society. He also visited France in 1832.
- In 1833 while visiting Bristol he fell ill and died on 27 September. Debendranath Tagore, Rajmohan Majumdar, Prasanna Kumar Tagore etc. were the followers of Rammohun Roy.